Present simple and present continuous

Goal: To use the present simple for habits, routines and general facts, and the present continuous for actions happening now or around now, and to choose the right tense from the time expressions in a sentence.

The idea in two lines: The present simple describes what is always or usually true (I work, she works). The present continuous (am/is/are + verb-ing) describes what is in progress at the moment of speaking or a temporary situation.

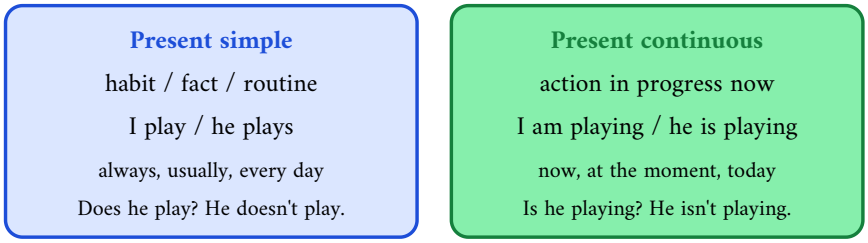


Figure 1: The two present tenses compared: form, use and typical time words.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Present simple form:** base verb for I / you / we / they; add **-s** (or -es after -s, -sh, -ch, -x, -o) for he / she / it: she watches, he goes.
2. **Present simple negatives and questions** use **do / does**: She does not (doesn't) like tea. Do they live here?
3. **Present simple uses:** habits and routines, permanent situations, general truths (Water boils at 100°C), timetables.
4. **Present continuous form:** am / is / are + verb-ing. Negative: is not (isn't) working. Question: Are you listening?
5. **Present continuous uses:** an action happening now, a temporary situation (I'm staying with my uncle this week), a changing situation (Prices are rising).
6. **Spelling of -ing:** make → making, sit → sitting, lie → lying.

7. **State verbs** (know, like, want, need, understand, believe) are normally used in the present simple, not the continuous.

🟢 Examples

1. My father (work) in a bank. He (not / work) today because it is Friday. **Answer:** works / is not working. **Explanation:** the first is a permanent job (simple); the second is a temporary situation around now (continuous).
2. Listen! Someone (knock) at the door. **Answer:** is knocking. **Explanation:** "Listen!" shows the action is in progress at this moment.
3. I (understand) the lesson now. **Answer:** understand. **Explanation:** "understand" is a state verb, so we keep the present simple even with "now".

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Forgetting the third-person **-s**: "he play" instead of "he plays".
- Keeping the -s after does / doesn't: "She doesn't likes" instead of "She doesn't like".
- Dropping the auxiliary in the continuous: "They playing" instead of "They are playing".
- Using state verbs in the continuous: "I am knowing the answer" instead of "I know the answer".

🟡 Quick review

- Habit, fact, routine → present simple (+ -s with he / she / it).
- Now, temporary, in progress → am / is / are + verb-ing.
- Questions and negatives in the simple need do / does.
- Time words are your clue: always, usually, every ↔ now, at the moment, look!
- State verbs (know, like, want) stay in the simple.

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